8 Working with data

This chapter covers

- Understanding the value of Entity Framework Core and how it works
- Managing the database schema with Entity Framework Core
- Using Entity Framework Core to query and manage data
- Scaffolding Razor Pages that work with Entity Framework Core and improving the output

So far we have concentrated our efforts on exploring features of the Razor Pages framework and how they work to generate HTML. This chapter takes a slight departure from that, focusing instead on a different framework known as Entity Framework Core (EF Core).

All but the simplest interactive web applications rely on the persistence and retrieval of data to support their dynamic content. That data is most often stored in and retrieved from a relational database of some kind. In the bad old days, the code required to manage these data access tasks was very repetitive. You would establish a connection to the database in code each time you wanted to communicate with the database, define the SQL query you wanted to execute, execute it, and capture the returned data in a low-level container, such as a `Recordset`, `DataTable`, or `DataReader`, and then process the data into some form your application could work with. The primary role of EF Core is to abstract that away, so you can concentrate on writing code to work with the data instead of code to retrieve it from a database. This chapter performs the basic CRUD